

# Berkeley Civic Engagement Agenda: UpSight call

UpSight internal · 2026-10-08 · Re: *The Civic Engagement Agenda for California's Next Governor*, UC Berkeley Possibility Lab, Sept 2026

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**Call: run a 4-week experiment on public data, kill date 15 Nov. Do not build a government sales motion.**

## What it is

- 20 asks to a governor who is not elected yet. Funding lands FY27-28 at the earliest.
- Core ask is a state "Civic Health Institute" that would fund the Lab's own programs. It is a bid for budget, not a buy.
- Authors are wired: Lerman (Lab founder), Melgar (California Endowment VP, ex-Newsom advisor), Maple (ex-State Auditor).

## "Open source" and who gets paid

- Action 10 says open-source tools because the Lab uses Pol.is and academics evaluate tools. It is a reference point, not a procurement rule.
- The state pays normal prices today: Ethelo (deliberation platform) ~\$135k, Carnegie \$106k, Nava \$677k spent / \$4M encumbered (ODI, FY24-25).
- Our line: never open-source the product. Offer an open "receipts" export format instead.

## Justify or compete

- Justifies us. Their principles call for "follow-through and accountability to the input." Carnegie's review of Engaged California asks for "receipts" by name.
- Real incumbent is ODI's in-house analytics (BERTopic + Claude 3.5 Sonnet), not the Lab.
- Risk: being studied for free instead of bought. Free demo on public data, then a priced pilot on theirs.

## Data

- Lab data: topline public, raw by agreement. Not gatekeeping, just academic.
- Worth asking for: Catalyst Convenings input (3 of 9 sessions, nothing published, rest pushed to 2027-28). They are behind.
- Already public: Engaged California LA-fires dataset. 1,289 comments, 11 topics, 38 AI groups, **30% left unthemed**, 19 policy actions issued, no comment-to-action map. Public domain.

## Money

### Now

- SGC RFQ: certified small business, 9 convenings 2027-28, includes “synthesis of meeting notes.” We would be a sub or a tool to the winner.
- ODI: already pays for this workflow; a second engagement (state workers) is planned.
- Cities and counties: every housing element must document public input; consultancies (CivicMakers, MIG, PlaceWorks) produce it. Same deliverable as our consultant beachhead.

### Later

- Civic Health Institute / Innovation Challenge: not funded, not yet proposed to anyone who can fund it. Nothing to plan on.

Sources: ODI Legislative Report 2025; SGC notice 28 Apr 2026; CivicMakers appendix, Santa Cruz County 2023.

## The demo

- Redo the state’s own analysis with receipts: “What 1,289 fire survivors said, what the state did with it, every claim linked.”
- Themes with every comment attached; the unthemed 30% regrouped; comment-to-action map for the 19 actions; assistant Q&A with citations via MCP.
- One public page. No slides.

## Plan

- Weeks 1-2: build on the public dataset. Weeks 3-4: outreach with the page in hand to the Lab, ODI, three engagement consultancies.
- Success by 15 Nov: one unpublished dataset handed over, or one paid pilot quoted. Meetings and compliments do not count.
- Kill: neither by 15 Nov. Keep the page as a reference asset.
- No Berkeley or state contacts in the CRM. Warm path is task one.

## Guardrails

- Non-partisan wording; no implied affiliation. Data-handling answer ready before outreach.
- Price the pilot after the demo. No year-long unpaid evaluation.

Refs: [possibilitylab.berkeley.edu/Civic%20Engagement%20Agenda.html](https://possibilitylab.berkeley.edu/Civic%20Engagement%20Agenda.html) · [engaged.ca.gov/lafires-recovery/agenda-setting-data-insights/](https://engaged.ca.gov/lafires-recovery/agenda-setting-data-insights/) · [carnegieendowment.org/posts/2025/11/engaged-california-la-wildfires-lessons](https://carnegieendowment.org/posts/2025/11/engaged-california-la-wildfires-lessons) · [innovation.ca.gov/reports/legislative-report-2025](https://innovation.ca.gov/reports/legislative-report-2025) · [sgc.ca.gov/?p=11435](https://sgc.ca.gov/?p=11435)